HEY THERE, NEW WRITER!

Copy guides for junior writers

Four short guides to how I write for a brand: the do’s, the don’ts, and prompts you can copy and paste.

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HOW TO PROMPT

Every prompt has *five lines.*

Role

Who the AI should be.

EX:
Senior conversion copywriter

Reader

Who it is writing for.

EX:
A founder worried about price

Facts

What it may use. Nothing else.

EX:
Your numbers, reviews and notes

Voice

How it sounds, and what it never says.

EX:
Plain and warm. Never “seamless”

Output

Exactly what to hand back.

EX:
5 headlines and 1 call to action

One line

Gets you an average answer, in an average voice.

Five lines

Gets you a draft you can actually use.

HOT TAKE Hot take: The prompt is the brief. If a human junior could not write from it, the AI cannot either.

WEBSITE

The guide

Say what changes for the customer. Then prove it.

Landing page

SELLS ONE PROMISE

- **Headline:** the outcome, not the product. The subhead says who it is for.
- **Proof:** a number, a name or a real review, right beside the claim.
- **Benefits:** three at most, in your customer’s own words.
- **One ask:** a single button that says what happens next.

Product description

ANSWERS THE LAST DOUBT

- Open with the benefit, then back it with the fact.
- Answer doubts: size, fit, care, delivery, returns.
- Sensory words beat adjectives. “Soft” beats “premium”.
- Check claims with legal. Even famous lines get challenged.

HOT TAKE Hot take: “Premium”, “innovative” and “seamless” are not copy, they are placeholders. When I see one in a draft, I ask what we actually mean.

WEBSITE

Do and don’t.

DO	DON’T
The classic · Apple, 2001 **“1,000 songs in your pocket.”** Same product. One lists the spec, the other describes your life.	The spec sheet **“5GB MP3 player.”**
Landing page · Airbnb “Belong anywhere.”	Landing page “A global marketplace for short-term stays.”
Product page · Apple “Titanium. So strong. So light. So Pro.”	Product page “A durable, lightweight titanium frame.”
Product line · Oatly “It’s like milk, but made for humans.”	Product line “A plant-based oat beverage alternative.”

WEBSITE

Copy and paste.

COPY AND PASTE

Landing page

```
You are a senior conversion copywriter. Write a landing
page for [PRODUCT].

Reader: [WHO THEY ARE], who is worried about [OBJECTION].

Use only these facts: [FACTS, NUMBERS, REVIEWS]. If a claim
is not backed by them, flag it instead of writing it.

Voice: [3 ADJECTIVES]. Never use: [BANNED WORDS].

Give me: 5 headlines that state an outcome, 1 subhead,
3 benefits with proof, and 1 call to action that says what
happens next.
```

COPY AND PASTE

Product description

```
You are a senior e-commerce copywriter. Write a product
description for [PRODUCT].

Customer: [WHO], choosing between this and [ALTERNATIVE].
Their biggest doubt: [DOUBT].

Use only these facts: [SPECS, MATERIALS, SIZES, REVIEWS].
Turn each into what it means for the customer. Flag
anything you cannot support.

Voice: [3 ADJECTIVES]. Never use: "premium",
"high-quality", "perfect for any occasion".

Give me: a one-line headline, a 40-word description,
4 bullets (benefit first, fact second) and one line that
answers the doubt.
```

> **Not this:** “Write a landing page for my product. Make it catchy and professional.” It gives the model nothing to work with, so you get clichés.

SOCIAL MEDIA

The guide

Win the first line. The rest only has to keep the promise.

Instagram

THREE SECONDS

- **Reels:** put the payoff on screen and out loud, straight away.
- **Captions:** the point goes in the first line. The feed cuts off the rest.
- **Proof:** show the real thing. A face, a number, the product.
- One post, one point. A second takeaway is a second post.

LinkedIn

A FEW LINES

- **Hook:** a result, a mistake, a contrarian take or a question.
- **Shape:** short lines, one idea each, a blank line between.
- **Story:** the situation, the turn, the lesson.
- **Ending:** one question your reader can answer in a line.

HOT TAKE Hot take: If your hook could open any brand’s post, it is not a hook. Make it so specific that only you could have written it.

SOCIAL MEDIA

Do and don’t.

DO	DON’T
The classic · Oreo, 2013 **“You can still dunk in the dark.”** It joined the conversation everyone was already having, in one line.	The brand line **“Our cookies are perfect for any occasion.”**
Instagram · Apple “Shot on iPhone.”	Instagram “Check out this amazing photo we took with our incredible camera!”
Hook · Spotify “Dear person who played ‘Sorry’ 42 times on Valentine’s Day...”	Hook “Millions of songs for every mood and moment.”
LinkedIn · shape Short lines. One idea each. A blank line between.	LinkedIn · shape One 200-word block that never breaks.

SOCIAL MEDIA

Copy and paste.

COPY AND PASTE

Draft the post

```
You are a social writer for [BRAND] on Instagram and
LinkedIn.

Reader: [WHO], who is stuck on [PROBLEM].

Angle: [ONE INSIGHT, STORY OR RESULT]. Use only these
notes: [PASTE NOTES].

Voice: [3 ADJECTIVES]. Never use: "excited to share",
"game-changer", "unlock".

Give me: 5 openers under 12 words, a LinkedIn post (short
lines, under [180] words, ending on one question) and an
Instagram caption (point in the first line).
```

COPY AND PASTE

Sharpen the hook

```
Here is my draft post: [PASTE].

Rewrite only the first line 5 ways: a result, a mistake,
a contrarian take, a question and a specific moment.

Score each from 1 to 5 on: specific, surprising, would I
stop scrolling?

Pick the best and say why in one sentence. Do not touch
the rest.
```

> **Not this:** “Write a LinkedIn post about our new feature.” There is no reader and no angle, so expect “Excited to announce...”.

BRAND VOICE

The guide

A voice is not adjectives. It is decisions.

The voice stays the same. The tone shifts with the moment.

Ask the founder

BEFORE YOU WRITE

- **Beliefs:** start with what they believe and who they serve, not a mood board.
- **Nevers:** ask what they would never say, and who they hate sounding like.
- **Samples:** collect five pieces of copy they are proud of.
- **Specifics:** push past “friendly and professional”.

Write the guide

WHILE YOU WRITE

- **The “not”:** give every trait one. Warm, not chatty.
- **Sentences:** show each trait in a before-and-after line.
- **Hard moments:** plan the error, the apology and the refund.
- **One page:** a new writer should be able to use it today.

HOT TAKE Hot take: A brand voice is what you refuse to say. The “nots” do more work than the adjectives.

BRAND VOICE

The dials.

Circle one dot per line. Filled dots show an example answer.



THEN ASK ABOUT MOMENTS

- How should we sound when a customer is angry?
- When we launch something big?
- When we make a mistake?
- When we explain something complicated?

HOT TAKE Hot take: Never accept “somewhere in between”. Middle of the road is how a brand ends up sounding like nobody.

BRAND VOICE

Do and don’t.

DO	DON’T
The classic · Mailchimp’s voice guide **“We are plainspoken. We are genuine. Our humor is dry.”** Traits a writer can act on. Each one tells you what to do next.	The usual version **“We’re friendly and professional.”**
Personality · Oatly “Yes, we are vegan. So?”	Personality “We are proud to offer plant-based options for conscious consumers.”
Voice vs tone · Mailchimp Same voice every day. A different tone for someone who is upset.	Voice vs tone One tone, everywhere, all the time.
Many markets Same voice, local words: “lift” in London, “elevator” in New York.	Many markets The same copy, translated word for word, in every market.

BRAND VOICE

Copy and paste.

QUESTIONNAIRE

Send this to the founder

- If our brand walked into a room, who would it be? Three words.
- What do we believe that our category does not?
- Who do we talk to, and what worries them at 11pm?
- Which brand’s voice do you love, and which would you hate to sound like?
- Which words would we never say?

COPY AND PASTE

Turn the answers into a voice guide

```
You are a brand strategist and senior writer. Here are the
founder's answers: [PASTE] and five pieces of copy they
love: [PASTE].

Find the three traits that show up in both. For each trait
write: what it sounds like, "we are X, not Y", a
before-and-after sentence, three words we use and three
we avoid.

Then add tone for a launch, an error and an apology.

Quote the founder's own words. Flag any answers that
contradict each other.
```

> **Not this:** “Create a tone of voice guide for our brand. We’re friendly and professional.” Every brand says that, so nothing tells a writer what to do.

YOUR VOICE

The guide

You already have a voice. Notice it, then make it deliberate.

Read your own writing like an editor who has never met you.

Notice

STEP ONE

- **Aloud:** read it out. Where you stumble, the sentence is wrong.
- **Length:** count the words in your last five sentences.
- **Tics:** list the words you overuse. “Just”, “really”, “very”.
- **Signature:** find the three lines that sound most like you.

Edit

STEP TWO

- **Rhythm:** put a short sentence next to a long one.
- **Hedges:** cut “just”, “I think” and the warm-up.
- **Plain words:** if a short word works, use it.
- **Keep:** the habits that sound like you. Break the rest.

HOT TAKE Hot take: You do not need to “find your voice”. You need to stop sanding it down.

YOUR VOICE

Do and don’t.

DO	DON’T
The classic · Avis, 1962 **“We try harder.”** Three words, an honest admission and a promise. Cut until it still sounds like you.	The usual version **“We are committed to continually improving our customer experience.”**
Hedges Can we talk Thursday?	Hedges I just wanted to quickly reach out to see if you might have some time to connect.
Opener Hi Sam, loved your talk on pricing.	Opener I hope this email finds you well.
Bio I write product pages that sell and onboarding emails people finish.	Bio Passionate marketer with a proven track record of driving results.

YOUR VOICE

Copy and paste.

QUESTIONNAIRE

Answer these first

- Read one piece aloud. Where do you stumble?
- Count the words in your last five sentences. Short, long or mixed?
- Do you plan first, or write to find out what you think?
- Which words do you overuse?
- What do you always delete in the edit?
- Whose writing do you copy, on purpose or by accident?

COPY AND PASTE

Let AI read your samples

```
You are an editor who reads for voice, not grammar. Here
are five samples of my writing: [PASTE]. Do not rewrite
them.

Describe my voice: average sentence length, words and
openers I repeat, how formal I am, how I use questions.

Quote the 3 lines that sound most like me and the 3 that
sound least, and say why.

Then give me 5 habits to keep and 3 to break. Evidence
over praise.
```

> **Not this:** “Analyse my writing style.” The model guesses, so you get flattery and a list of adjectives.

CHECKLIST

Before it ships.

WEBSITE

- [ ] Headline states the outcome
- [ ] Every claim has proof
- [ ] One ask, one clear verb
- [ ] Product details match the product
- [ ] Read aloud: sounds human

SOCIAL MEDIA

- [ ] First line works alone
- [ ] One idea, nothing extra
- [ ] Cut for the platform
- [ ] Ends on a real question
- [ ] Facts and tags checked

BRAND VOICE

- [ ] Every trait has a “not”
- [ ] Real before-and-after lines
- [ ] Hard moments planned
- [ ] Fits on one page
- [ ] Founder says “that’s us”

YOUR VOICE

- [ ] Read aloud, no stumbles
- [ ] Short next to long
- [ ] Hedges and filler cut
- [ ] Still sounds like you
- [ ] Cut the first line: still works?

HOT TAKE Hot take: AI can draft it. Only a person can check it. Every fact, price and claim gets read by a human.

Thank you.

Four guides, four checklists and ten prompts. Take what works, ignore what does not, and tell me which parts you argued with.

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